DESERT ROSE (GYPSUM)

  Desert Roses are formations named for their layered, rose-like structures that resemble blooming flowers.	**Characteristics:** Desert rose is a special formation of gypsum ($CaSO_4 \cdot 2H_2O$), a calcium sulfate mineral and, occasionally, barite. The "petals" are crystals flattened on the c axis, fanning open in radiating clusters. **Natural Occurrences:** In arid regions, desert roses are formed when groundwater gradually dissolves the gypsum in sedimentary rocks. water evaporates, $CaSO_4$ becomes oversaturated, prompting gypsum to precipitate. Crystals then start to form within cavities or sediment layers, often resembling rosette-like structure hence the name.